

GRAMMAR OF AGENCY

Moral Action in an Age of Artificial Intelligence

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Preface

This capstone takes its name in deliberate dialogue with St. John Henry Newman's *Grammar of Assent*. Newman argued that real certitude arises not from mechanical inference (mere syllogistic logic applied) but from the convergence of interior faculties — a unity of mind, will, and perception - an interior integrity across domains. The *Grammar of Agency* stands on the same ground: that moral action, like assent, is not a mechanical output but a disciplined interior event. Where Newman traced the epistemic movement toward truth, this work traces the moral movement toward the good.

I can't possibly thank all of those involved in the preparation of this document, but without my Lay Mission disciple group out of St. Isidore's parish in Danville, California and my fellow brothers and sisters at St. Albert the Great's Lay Dominican Fraternity in Oakland, this would not have been possible. For all involved, I am deeply and eternally grateful. This is offered as seed to be spread.

Introduction

We live in a world increasingly shaped, fitted, and mediated by artificial intelligence. Our phones no longer simply let us talk to mom; they tell us the time, they track our steps, monitor our sleep, measure our heartbeats, and anticipate our needs. Most of us cannot recall a best friend's phone number, read a map, or navigate by compass — because the machine does it for us, faster and more reliably than we can. Bit by bit, we have outsourced formerly human-only skills to systems designed by others to optimize utility and maximize efficiency of . . . ourselves? Really? But it's free — or so we assume. Free, even as our desires and micro-behaviors are quietly siphoned away, reforming in a *myst* — that bank of fog creeping in, sensed, dealt, smelt, felt, being reshaped by the machine — and fed back to us as persuasion. Ever mention something aloud and see it appear in your feed? Free, right. Are our desires our own anymore? Do we even have an interior space? Or, have we, for efficiency and optimization, outsourced that too?

The question is no longer whether we will outsource. It is what remains when we have outsourced everything we can. We have ceded capacities to machines. We are also slowly ceding ourselves — the Witness Moment, the interiority necessary for discernment, for purposeful action. Bit by bit we've outsourced the skills we once possessed — and thus, voluntarily, lost — and, accordingly, maybe without realizing it, ceded our very agency, our autonomy, our freedom for excellence. What we are outsourcing, almost without noticing, is the very judgment by which we once governed ourselves.

At some point, the outsourcing must stop. And it must stop with us — with an interior stance, a posture of agency: I will not offload my moral responsibility to the machine. AI cannot parse a moral plane. Its outputs have form without substance, fluency without accountability. An AI response is not an act. It does not relate to the real world; it receives inputs and produces outputs. It does not stand before the good. It does not choose. This capstone argues that the only stable response to an automated age is the

deliberate formation of human agency through a structural architecture that unites virtue, timing, and presence.

"But I trust my phone," someone might say. "I use it every day." Fair enough. But what about your car? Increasingly, people allow their vehicles to drive themselves while they sit back, perhaps paying attention, perhaps not. When the system misses something and someone is harmed, who is responsible? The machine processed the data. The machine issued the command. The machine executed the maneuver. Is that an act?

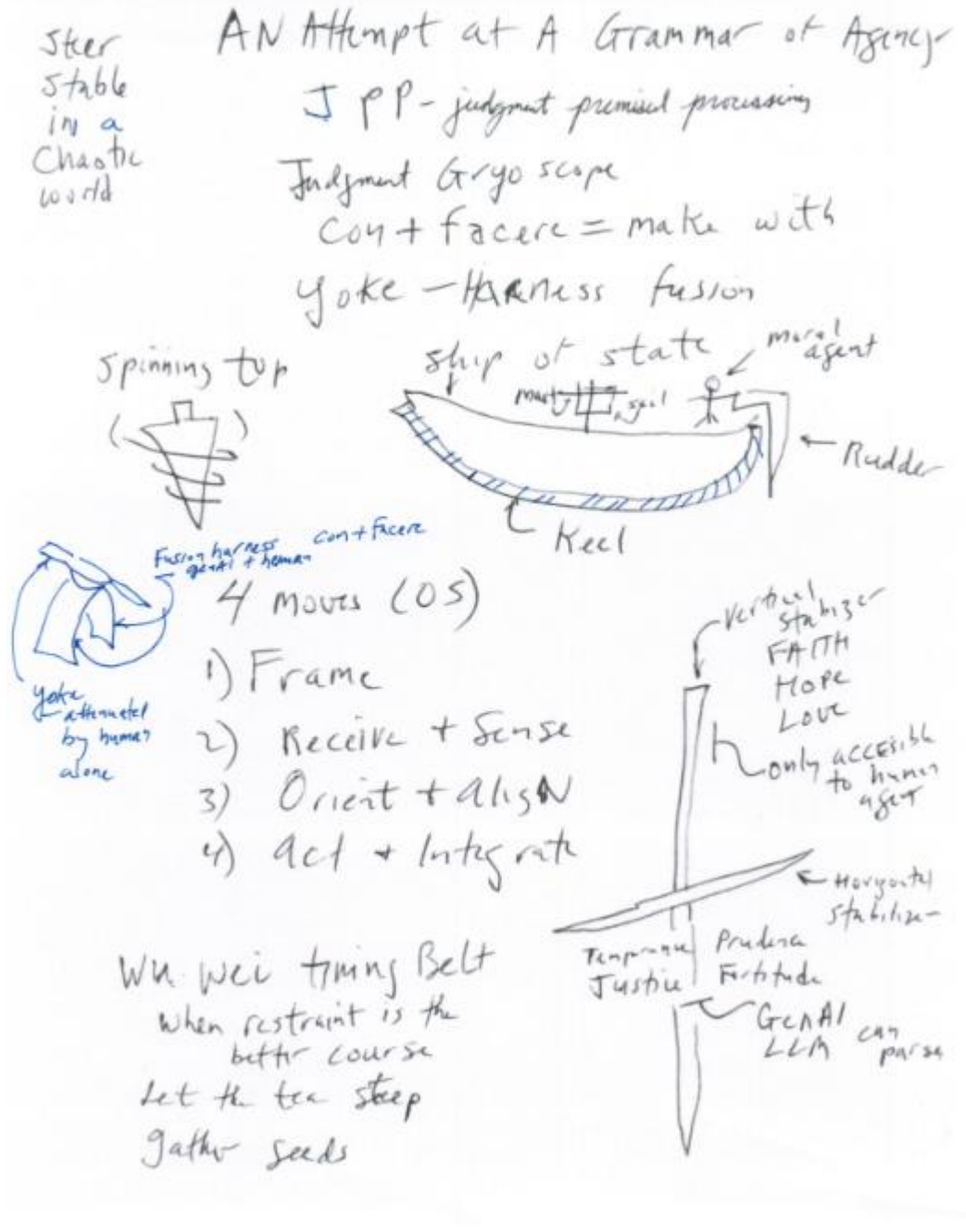
Not in the Thomistic sense of *actus* of a human agent. The driver initiated the sequence, set the *telos*, and surrendered vigilance. If you start the ball rolling, are you not responsible for the avalanche that follows?

This is the field we now inhabit — a moral landscape in which artificial systems perform more and more of the tasks that once required human judgment, attention, and will. The Grammar of Agency is an attempt to name that field, to map its contours, and to recover the distinctly human capacity for intentional, virtuous action within it.

This capstone begins with a simple claim: *in an age of artificial intelligence, the most urgent task is the formation of human agency.*

Not information transfer. Not technique acquisition. Formation — the slow, deliberate, habituated shaping of the moral person so that when the moment arrives, the right act arises not from calculation but from character. This is what the Dominican tradition has always understood. This is what the Lay Mission Institute exists to transmit. And this is what no artificial intelligence, however fluent, however fast, however vast its training, can either perform or replace.

Section I: The Problem of Agency in an AI Age



The Mechanism of Displacement

The problem of agency in an AI age is not simply that machines now do things humans once did. It is that the outsourcing of cognitive and moral tasks does not leave the human agent intact and merely unburdened. It reshapes the agent. When navigation is permanently delegated to GPS, spatial reasoning does not merely rest — it atrophies.

When a recommendation engine curates every cultural encounter, the capacity for self-directed attention contracts. The loss is not the skill itself but the interior architecture that the skill required and sustained: the habit of judgment, the tolerance for ambiguity, the willingness to be wrong and correct course.

This is the specific mechanism by which AI degrades moral agency — not through malice or design, but through the logic of optimization itself. A system optimized to minimize friction in decision-making will, over time, minimize the decision-maker. It will anticipate before the agent has framed the question, recommend before the agent has sensed the field, and execute before the agent has oriented toward the good. The four moves of JPP — Frame, Receive and Sense, Orient and Align, Act and Integrate — are not merely bypassed. They are made to feel unnecessary. And what feels unnecessary, we stop practicing. What we stop practicing, we lose the ability to perform.

The sketch above maps the architecture that the *Grammar of Agency* proposes in response: a ship of state in which the moral agent is not a passenger but the operator — steering stable in a chaotic world through the fusion of judgment and making with (Con+Facere), held on course by the keel of revelation, tradition and practice which provide a foundation for cardinal virtues on the horizontal plan of proportion and relation, stabilized vertically by the transcendent virtues of Faith, Hope, and Love, and timed by wu wei. The spinning top is gyroscopic stability. The yoke-harness is the interface between human agency and the field. The rudder is prudential judgment in motion. These elements are elaborated in the sections that follow. The problem of agency is the problem of maintaining all of them — simultaneously, under load — in a world designed to make each one feel optional. Where each virtue and the timing of practice is slowly stripped away until all that is left is a mere consumer, or, rather, a data point to influence and monetize.

Section II: The Thomistic Foundation

Conscience as Act, Not Power

To understand why the *Grammar of Agency* makes the claims it does, we must begin where Aquinas begins: with the nature of conscience itself. In the *Summa Theologiae* (I, Q. 79, A. 13), Aquinas asks whether conscience is a power of the soul. His answer is precise and consequential: conscience is not a power but an act — the act of applying knowledge to an individual case. The Latin etymology reveals the architecture: *conscientia*, knowledge held together with, knowledge applied in the moment of encounter. Conscience is *cum alio scientia* — knowledge brought to bear on a particular situation. Thus, for Thomas, conscience is an act (*actus*), not a *habitus*. A moment, not a disposition.

This matters enormously for how we understand moral errors. If conscience were a power — a faculty we simply possess — then moral failure would be a malfunction, a failure of equipment. But Aquinas tells us conscience is an act, which means moral failure is a failure of performance. And performance can be disciplined, trained, habituated. This is the opening through which formation enters.

The *Catechism of the Catholic Church* (§37) reinforces the point from the phenomenological direction. Human reason is genuinely capable of attaining moral truth — but in practice it is hampered at every turn: by the impact of the senses, by the imagination, and above all by disordered appetites. The result is that men easily persuade themselves that what they would not like to be true is instead false or at least doubtful. The easiest lie to believe is the one you want to be true. But, in fact, you know it is not true. That is the seed of disordered will.

This is the diagnostic that the *Grammar of Agency* takes as its starting point: error is rarely about lack of intelligence. It is almost always about disordered will. The intellect is not broken; it is bent by appetite. Formation is the discipline of the will, by practice of the body and prayer of the heart, all of which can produce pain, sorrow and agony. The journey is worth it, it's not just plowing the field, it is leaping with the hinds on the mountains and elevating. Only the vertical virtues of Faith, Hope and Love reside and thrive in that domain of elevation. The horizontal field of optimized specious pulp has no real value without those virtues.

The Two-Axis Model: What AI Can and Cannot Do

The *Grammar of Agency* rests on a two-axis architecture that clarifies precisely what artificial intelligence can simulate and what it cannot enter.

The horizontal axis is the plane of the cardinal virtues: Prudence, Justice, Fortitude, and Temperance. These virtues have definable criteria, measurable distortions, recognizable signatures, and predictable consequences. A large language model can reason about justice with fluency, describe prudent action with precision, model temperance, and advise on fortitude. The horizontal plane is, in a precise sense, LLM-legible. AI lives here naturally and can provide genuine assistance to a human agent navigating this plane.

The vertical axis is the transcendent spine that only a human agent can engage. It is animated by Faith — trust that the good is worth pursuing; Hope — orientation toward a redeemable future; and Love — the governing intention toward the dignity of the other. These exceed calculation, cannot be automated, and belong uniquely to the human soul in its capacity for self-transcendence.

AI can describe what a just act looks like. It cannot perform one. It can model temperance with precision. It cannot place the Kind bar and wait. Without the vertical stabilizer, the horizontal plane is merely optimization: fast, fluent, and flat.

A tension worth naming: if AI assistance on the horizontal plane is genuine, the formed agent must approach it with care. An agent whose vertical axis is not engaged may receive AI guidance on prudence or justice as though it were a substitute for the interior act of judgment rather than a prompt toward it. The horizontal help is real. But an agent who outsources the horizontal moves without the vertical axis orienting the whole does not receive assistance — they receive replacement. The two-axis model is not a license for selective delegation; it is a map of what must remain irreducibly human. The vertical axis is not a supplement to the system. It is the condition under which the system is moral at all.

Truth as the Epistemological Ground

Underlying both axes is a prior commitment about the nature of truth itself. Aquinas, in the *Summa Theologiae* (I, Q. 16, A. 6), argues that truth is one in its ground — derived from the single divine intellect by analogy — and many in its reception, instantiated in particular knowing subjects. Many truths are reflected from the one divine truth, as from one face many likenesses are reflected in a mirror.

The implication is foundational: truth is not produced by the human mind. It is received. Conscience is not an authority that invents truth but a faculty that receives, recognizes, and applies it. This establishes the epistemological posture the Grammar of Agency requires: humility. Truth is something we submit to before it is something we use. Formation begins in this submission — in the willingness to be wrong, to be corrected, to receive rather than generate the measure of the good. Truth is received, not produced, thus, formation begins with posture, stance, preparation with the flow of the field.

This stance of humility acknowledges the Creator — we are created, that is our initial presentation into this world. It is relational; the child is borne of a mother, so there are at least two people in the relationship. Both came into a world that already was there, with meaning, struggles and joy. We are capable of joy in experiencing creation and our place in it. The order, the beauty, the truth. All preexisting our presence. And which will endure when we leave this plane.

Section III: The Grammar in Motion — CST-JPP

The CST Fourfold Test: Altitude Instrument

Catholic Social Teaching, in the *Grammar of Agency*, is not a library of principles to be consulted after the fact. It is an operator's manual for moments — a way of reading the field that gives the agent moral altitude: clarity about what kind of moment they are in and what it is asking of them. The tradition is rendered as four questions, asked before action:

- Does this action restore human dignity?
- Does it seed the garden of the common good?
- Is it sisterly and brotherly — does it strengthen solidarity?
- Does it uplift the little ones?

If the answer is not yes to all four, the action is not yet just. These are not a checklist to be completed and filed. They are an altitude instrument — a continuous reading of the moral field that the agent carries into every situation, mapping directly onto CST's four pillars: human dignity, common good, solidarity, and the preferential option for the poor.

JPP: The Four Moves as Kata

Judgment Premised Processing (JPP) is the steering mechanism — a kata for disciplined action when the world is loud and ambiguous. Where CST clarifies what

matters, JPP clarifies what to do. It is structured as four moves, repeatable in sequence, forming disposition through praxis:

- **Frame.** Take in the moment. Achieve self-awareness and field awareness simultaneously. Snap in — be fully present to what is actually happening, not what you anticipated or feared.
- **Receive and Sense.** Be actively passive. Open to what the moment is delivering before moving to interpret it. The senses gather; the intellect has not yet formed its judgment. This move requires stillness — the discipline of not rushing to conclusion.
- **Orient and Align.** Frame with purpose and direction. Turn toward the good. Align posture, intention, and proportion. Ask: what is the right act here, for this person, in this moment, given what is at stake?
- *The Space Between: Discernment in the Moment*
- **Act and Integrate.** Now, in this moment, act. Assess and iterate. Stability provides closure: clean, with no ripple left. The act is complete when the field has been met and the agent has returned to readiness.

The kata is portable. It can be run in thirty seconds or thirty minutes. Formation is the work of making the kata reflexive before the high-stakes moment arrives. But between the third and fourth move there is a *threshold* — *the most important and most neglected moment in the entire sequence*.

Wu Wei: The Timing Belt

Between Orient and Align and Act and Integrate there is a threshold. Before naming it, intellectual honesty requires acknowledging where its deepest philosophical roots form: not in 13th-century Paris, but in ancient China, in the classical Taoist tradition, more than fourteen centuries before Thomas Aquinas was born.

Lao Tzu composed the *Tao Te Ching* (道德經) in the 6th century BC, in the Zhou dynasty of ancient China. Its central concern is the nature of the Tao: the Way, the underlying current of reality that cannot be named, only aligned with. And its most demanding practical teaching is *wu wei* — 無為 — the discipline of action that does not force, 非強為” (*fei qiang wei* — *not forced action*).

Wu wei is not passivity. It is not indifference. It is not quietism. It is the discipline of action that does not precede its natural moment — that allows reality to complete its own disclosure before the agent moves to meet it. *Wu wei* is not the virtue; it is the temporal discipline that allows the virtues to operate without distortion.

Thomas Aquinas, writing in 13th-century Paris, arrives at a formulation that resonates powerfully across the nineteen-century gap: prudence as *recta ratio agibilium* — right reason applied to action. Aquinas gives us the rational architecture of right judgment — the what and the why of prudential action. The Tao gives us the temporal wisdom of right timing — when and the how not just yet. And to be prepared, to act when that preparation meets opportunity. Together, what to do and when to do it, they constitute a complete account of moral action that neither tradition achieves alone.

Mantra: Let the tea steep. Gather seeds. Scent tea. Palm seeds. Breathe. Ground.

Mary's Fiat: Prudence In Docile Acceptance

The perfected integration of *wu wei* and *recta ratio agibilium*

In this, our Blessed Mother stands as the clearest human exemplar. Across the **Annunciation**, **Cana**, and **Calvary**, she reveals a single interior stance: not passivity, but formed readiness—prudence perfected in timing.

All three mysteries—**Annunciation**, **Cana**, and **Calvary**—reveal the same interior stance: Mary stands at the threshold between **Orient & Align** and **Act & Integrate** with perfect readiness. At the **Annunciation**, she receives what she does not yet understand, inquires proportionately, holds the moment open, and consents only when discernment has completed its interior work. At **Cana**, she notes the disturbance—“They have no wine”—names the need, prepares the field, and steps back into the timing belt: “Do whatever he tells you.” No forcing, no scripting, only formed readiness. At **Calvary**, she enacts this same posture under maximal load: she stands, present to the horror, grounded in faith and hope wrapped in love, neither collapsing nor attempting to seize control of what cannot be controlled.

In each mystery, Mary embodies the union of temporal *wu wei* and Thomistic right action. She receives, interiorizes, and holds the moment in her heart until the act that is hers to perform becomes clear. And when the moment opens, her action—whether consent, preparation, or standing fast—is exact, proportionate, and fully aligned with the good. Her stillness is not passivity but the highest form of prudence: disciplined openness to the right act at the right time.

The Silicon Valley Inversion — and Why It Matters Now

The urgency of recovering this ancient, time-tested, and trans-cultural wisdom is specific and contemporary. The dominant culture of technological development — centered in Silicon Valley but now global in its reach and cultural authority — has made a virtue and an economy out of the systematic elimination of the threshold between discernment and action. Move fast and break things. Ship before you're ready. Fail forward. Iterate at speed. Disruption as default posture.

This is *wu wei* inverted. It is not simply the absence of patience — it is the active, culturally enforced destruction of the conditions that make patience possible. The timing belt has not merely been neglected; it has been removed and celebrated in its removal. The threshold between discernment and action — the space between thought and act, that both Aquinas and Lao Tzu recognized as the locus of genuine moral judgment — has been reengineered as inefficiency, as friction, as competitive disadvantage to be eliminated.

The *Grammar of Agency* names this clearly: the elimination of the timing belt is not a competitive advantage. It is a moral failure. And the recovery of *wu wei* — of the active, disciplined restraint that holds the threshold open while discernment completes its work — is not a retreat from the modern world. Taking the time to discern; to let intellect

manage will and appetite; is the only path back to agency, autonomy, and authentic human moral action.

The Timing Belt in Practice

In the *Grammar of Agency*, *wu wei* (prudential patience) functions as the timing belt that connects **Orient and Align** to **Act and Integrate**. It is the active discipline of restraint — not the absence of agency but its most refined expression. The agent who has oriented toward the good and aligned with right intention now holds still. Not from paralysis. Not from fear. But from the knowledge that the moment has not yet fully opened, and that premature action is itself a form of distortion.

The mantra that anchors this threshold in practice carries six beats, each one a micro-practice of *wu wei* — of holding the threshold open while discernment completes its interior work:

Let the tea steep. Gather seeds. Scent tea. Palm seeds. Breathe. Ground.

The tea does not steep faster because you are watching it. The seed does not germinate on demand. The moral moment does not open on command. The agent who knows this waits — not passively, but with the active, attentive, disciplined stillness that the Zhuangzi calls the natural posture of the skilled person and that Aquinas calls the patience proper to prudence. This is the timing belt. This is what is missing from Silicon Valley. This is what formation must restore.

The Agent-Influencer-Witness Triad: Relational Geometry

No moral moment is inhabited by one person alone. The *Grammar of Agency* names three roles that are always present, whether or not they are occupied by distinct persons. The **Agent** is the human moral actor who performs the *actus* — who carries the vertical axis and bears sole responsibility for the act. The **Influencer** is any force — person, system, structure, or context — that shapes the field in which the Agent acts, but does not act in the Agent's place. The algorithm that curates your feed is an Influencer. The community of formation is an Influencer. So is the cultural air of Silicon Valley that makes speed feel virtuous. The **Witness** is the tertiary evaluator who reads the moral vector of the moment — and testifies only when systemic disturbance threatens the Agent's autonomy. When autonomy is intact and the kata is running cleanly, the Witness remains silent. This triad — Con+Facere, “to make with” — names the irreducibly communal nature of moral action: the Agent acts, but never alone. Formation is always shared. The Witness Moment is always witnessed.

The Witness Moment: Where the System Proves Itself

Everything in the *Grammar of Agency* converges on a single instant: the **Witness Moment**. This is the *actus* — the decisive, embodied action of the agent — the hinge between intention and consequence, the only moment where agency is real.

Aquinas distinguishes the exterior act — the physical thing done — from the interior act — the choosing, the willing, the orienting toward the good that precedes and animates the exterior act. The **Witness Moment** is the instant when the interior act penetrates the

horizontal plane and enters the world. It is where virtue becomes testimony. Where the vertical axis touches the real. Where the timing belt releases and the wind moves the sail.

An AI cannot create a **Witness Moment**. It can process the field. It can describe what a witness moment looks like. It cannot stand in one — because standing requires presence, and presence requires a soul.

Section IV: The Grammar in Action — Case Studies

Theory without demonstration is philosophy. The *Grammar of Agency* makes its strongest claims in concrete moments — in the controlled conditions of a pedagogical exercise and in the wild conditions of real human encounter. The following two case studies demonstrate JPP's operational coherence across distinct domains of formation and encounter.

Case Study 1: The Taffy Toss — The Controlled Demonstration in situ

The Objective Narrative

A seminar room. Thirteen seats arranged around a table, six occupied. The presenter stands at the front. A handout has been distributed. The session on JPP is about to begin.

Without preamble or explanation, the presenter turns away from the audience and reaches for a supply of individually wrapped saltwater taffy — enough for thirteen, though only six are present. He turns back toward the table and tosses the candy across it in a single, generous motion. The taffy scatters freely. There is more than enough. The field is open. Resources are unlimited. Anyone may take as much as they want.

Participants reach for the taffy. They take pieces. Some unwrap one immediately. The atmosphere is informal, easy. The gesture reads as a gift — an opening move of generosity before the work begins.

The presenter turns away again. This time, when he turns back, he holds a single Kind bar. He does not toss it. He does not distribute it. He walks to the table and places it — deliberately, quietly, without comment. He sets it down at the center of the table. He steps back. He says nothing. He waits.

Nobody takes the Kind bar.

The room goes still. Eyes move to the bar, then to the presenter, then back to the bar. Hands that might have reached do not reach. The pause lasts several seconds — longer than is comfortable. Nobody speaks. Nobody takes. Nobody explains why they are not taking.

The exercise is complete.

The Analysis

The taffy toss is the AI operating environment made visible. Unlimited resources across an open field. Relational access, proportionate distribution, instantaneous availability, no moral weight. This is the matrix in which a large language model operates naturally. AI lives permanently in the toss. It cannot do what happens next.

The Kind bar placement is a different category of action entirely. Before the hand moves, something has already happened inside. The presenter has framed the situation, received and sensed the field, oriented and aligned toward a deliberate act — and then held the timing belt. Wu wei between Orient and Act. The threshold honored. The discernment allowed to complete. Only then the placement: deliberate, quiet, without explanation.

Nobody takes the Kind bar because the field changed. The placement introduced a Witness — a human being who acted deliberately, who placed something with intention, who is now present and waiting. The participants feel that presence before their minds can form a thought about it.

The hesitation is the proof that the system is working. It is the most important moment in the exercise — not the toss, not the placement, but the pause in which every person in the room discovers, without being told, that they already know the difference between the two. Formation does not install a new capacity. It cultivates one that was already there, waiting for the moment to call it forward.

Case Study 2: The Buddhist March on Petersburg — The Grammar in the Wild

The Field

The Buddhist foot-marchers come in slow and steady, the way only people who've walked a hundred miles can move — not tired, but tuned. Their saffron robes catch the winter sun. Padding alongside them, tail up, is Ashoka, the stray mutt who adopted them somewhere around Dinwiddie and never left.

As they crest the hill into Petersburg, they meet the welcome party: the Methodist pastor with her stole tucked into her coat, the AME choir director holding a thermos of sweet tea, the civic association president with a clipboard he doesn't really need, three teenagers from the local Wicca circle wearing cloaks they absolutely do need, and a few curious onlookers who just wanted to see the dog.

Inside the old tobacco auction house — now the Farmers Market, its rafters still faintly smelling of cured leaf and history — long tables are already set: cornbread, dal, collards, dumplings, sweet potato pies, and a pot of something spicy that no one can identify but everyone wants to try. The field is warm, open, unguarded.

The Disturbance

Then, from the far corner of the building, comes a sharp voice. A cluster of intellectual agitators has gathered, arms crossed, notebooks out, ready to pounce. "This is syncretism! Buddhism doesn't march with Christians!" Another: "Christianity is being

diluted by this ecumenical spectacle!" A third: "Wicca has nothing to do with your peace-march theatrics!"

They are not speaking to the marchers. They are speaking to each other — a closed loop of grievance. But the field wobbles. Not violently. Just enough to feel the tilt.

The Proportionate Responses

What happens next is not planned, not coordinated, not strategic. It is proportionate — each response the product of a formed disposition expressing itself through the timing belt: held just long enough, then released with minimum necessary force.

- The Buddhist monk bows slightly and says: "We walk with whoever walks." No argument. No defense. Just clarity.
- The Methodist pastor steps forward, hands in her pockets: "Hospitality isn't dilution. It's hospitality." She doesn't raise her voice. She doesn't need to.
- The Wiccan teen shrugs: "We're literally just here for the dog." Ashoka wags on cue.
- The AME choir director laughs: "If you think this is syncretism, you've never been to a potluck." The room cracks open with warmth.

The Analysis

None of these responses could have been scripted, optimized, or generated by an AI prompted to "respond to criticism." Each required embodied presence, read context, and moral character formed over time. Each was an actus in the full Thomistic sense. And each carried the signature of wu wei: the brief, unnoticed pause before the response — the timing belt held just long enough for clarity to form — and then the proportionate word, delivered without excess. The field disturbance did not require aggressive correction; it required moral poise.

The horizontal virtues held the plane: temperance in the pastor's quiet voice, justice in the monk's inclusive clarity, fortitude in standing to respond at all, prudence in each proportionate reply. The vertical axis — the human presence, the humor, the shared dignity — stabilized the field. The agitators had nowhere to go. Their script didn't fit the moment. The field reset. The feast resumed.

This is the Grammar of Agency in the wild: not a technique applied, but a disposition expressed.

Section V. The Dominican Lineage: *Contemplata Aliis Tradere*

The Grammar of Agency does not emerge from abstraction. It emerges from within the Dominican intellectual tradition — the same tradition that produced Thomas Aquinas and animated the Order of Preachers for eight centuries under the principle *contemplata aliis tradere*: share with others the fruits of contemplation.

This is not a slogan. It is a structural commitment: that contemplation and action are not opposed but sequential. The formed agent first receives — in prayer, in study, in

community — and then gives. The giving is the mission. But the giving is only possible because the receiving came first. Aquinas did not just study; he prayed before he wrote. This is *wu wei* in Dominican form: the contemplative pause before the proclamation, the interior act completed before the exterior act begins.

St. Hyacinth of Poland embodies this principle with particular force. Six months of formation at Santa Sabina under Dominic himself — and then twenty-five thousand miles on foot across Russia, Sweden, Norway, Prussia, and the Northern nations of Asia. The six months was not insufficient. It was exactly sufficient — because formation is not about the quantity of content transmitted but the quality of disposition formed. Dominic set the gyroscope spinning. It kept spinning through every field disturbance the mission encountered.

Section VI. What the Lay Mission Institute Is For

The Lay Mission Institute exists to form lay missionary disciples — lay persons who carry the Dominican charism of truth-seeking, truth-living, and truth-sharing into the specific fields of their vocations: family, profession, parish, civic life, culture. Not clerics. Not religious. Lay persons, in the world, equipped with the same formation architecture that sent Hyacinth across twenty-five thousand miles.

The Grammar of Agency is an attempt at rendering this formation architecture explicit. It does not add something foreign to the Dominican tradition. It articulates what the tradition has always known and practiced — now enriched by the Taoist wisdom on timing and silence that ancient China has been holding for twenty-six centuries — in terms legible to the contemporary moment.

The capstone claim is simple. The gyroscope must be spinning before the moment arrives. The timing belt must be internalized before the field disturbance. The kata must be in the body before the Witness Moment calls it forward. Because when the moment comes — and it will come, without announcement, when it matters most — no AI will place the Kind bar.

Only the formed human agent can do that.

Section VII: Redemption — Retain, Retrain, Restrain

The Grammar of Agency has, until now, been oriented toward the moment of right action: the formed agent, timing belt engaged, moving with clarity and proportion through the **Witness Moment**. But formation is not a one-time acquisition. Agents fail. Dispositions drift. Kata, practiced imperfectly, encodes error as well as virtue. The question that every serious formation architecture must answer is not only how to shape the agent before the moment, but what to do after the agent has acted badly — and knows it.

Redemption, in the *Grammar of Agency*, is not a theological addendum. It is a structural necessity. The agent who cannot recover from moral failure is not a stable moral agent at all — they are an agent waiting to be disabled by their own history. The

Grammar of Agency offers a three-move sequence for moral recovery: **Retain, Retrain, Restrain**.

Retain: Keep What Is Essential

The first error a failed agent makes is not the original act. It is the wholesale rejection of everything that preceded it. Ashamed of a distorted **Witness Moment**, the agent discards the kata, abandons the framework, and retreats from the very formation that might have prevented the failure. This is what the *Grammar of Agency* calls collapse into self-erasure — a disordered response to disorder that compounds the original harm.

Retain is the first move of moral recovery because it establishes what is not in question. The vertical axis — faith, hope, love — is not forfeit by a single failure. These are not tools that a failed agent earned and can now be stripped of. They are the architecture of the agent's own moral identity. **Retain** is an act of disciplined honesty: the agent identifies what failed — and what did not.

Retrain: Modify Behavior by Adjusting

Having retained what is essential, the agent faces the specific work of moral recovery: not replacement but adjustment. **Retrain** is the *Grammar of Agency's* answer to the CCC §37 diagnosis — that moral failure is almost never a failure of intelligence but of disordered will. Recovery is the deliberate, patient re-habitation of the same capacities that failed.

Retrain operates at the level of the kata. The agent who retrains returns to the specific move that failed — **Frame, Receive and Sense, Orient and Align**, or the threshold itself — and runs it again, slowly, under low-stakes conditions, with the Influencer community present and the **Witness** function active. And the Taoist tradition contributes a precision here: retraining cannot be forced. *Wu wei* applies to recovery as much as it applies to initial action. The tea must steep again.

Restrain: Integrate Prudence

Restrain does not mean suppress. It does not mean the returned agent operates under a permanent diminishment. It means the agent who has failed, and who has retrained, now integrates prudence as a structural feature of their operation rather than as an occasional corrective.

Before the failure, the timing belt may have been engaged as a technique — a learned behavior, externally applied. After the recovery, **Restrain** means the timing belt has been internalized as identity. The agent does not hold the threshold open because the formation architecture prescribes it. They hold it open because they have lived the cost of failing to.

This is the paradox at the heart of **Restrain**: the agent who has passed through moral failure and genuine recovery is, in one specific and irreplaceable sense, more capable than the agent who has not. The recovered agent carries a lived map of their own vulnerabilities. This knowledge, rightly held, becomes a form of prudential capital —

self-knowledge deployed in the service of sustained moral agency. Because the human agent can fail but is not reducible to failure.

No artificial intelligence can move through this sequence. The **Redemption** sequence — **Retain, Retrain, Restrain** — is as exclusively human as the **Witness Moment** itself.

Section VIII: What If Witness Encounters an Irrational Agent?

Non-Violent, Actively Passive Containment of an Irrational Agent

There are moments when the field ceases to behave like a field — when a human actor enters in a state of irrationality, distortion, or interior collapse so severe that ordinary influence no longer functions. In such moments, the operator cannot rely on persuasion, dialogue, or shared rational ground. The task is no longer to shape the field but to contain it — non-violently, proportionately, and without surrendering agency.

Containment is not domination. It is not force. It is not argument. It is a non-violent, actively passive stance: a disciplined resistance that prevents further harm while preserving the dignity of all involved.

The Containment Stance: Three Moves

Still the Field. The operator reduces motion, noise, and escalation. This is *wu wei* in its purest form: do nothing that adds force to the moment. Stillness is not withdrawal. It is the active removal of fuel.

Hold the Boundary. The operator becomes a living perimeter — a stabilizing presence that prevents the irrational agent from expanding the disturbance. Calm tone, slow movements, proportionate distance, non-reactive posture, refusal to mirror the irrationality. The operator becomes the yoke.

Absorb Without Internalizing. The irrational agent may project, accuse, distort, or lash out verbally. The operator receives the impact without letting it penetrate the vertical axis. Temperance (no reactive excess), Fortitude (no collapse), Prudence (no premature action), Justice (no dehumanization). The operator becomes the stabilizer.

The Timing Belt Under Maximum Load

Containment is where the timing belt earns its name. The irrational agent is operating in *wei* — forced action, distorted timing. Containment requires *wu wei* — disciplined non-forcing.

Let the tea steep. Breathe. Ground. Hold.

This is not delay. It is temporal integrity under pressure — tensegrity expressed through non-forcing.

Why Containment Is Not Coercion

Coercion overrides agency. Containment protects agency — the operator's, the Witness's, and even the irrational agent's. Coercion says: I will force you. Containment says: I will not let this moment collapse. Coercion escalates. Containment stabilizes. Coercion violates dignity. Containment preserves it. Containment, too, is a Witness Moment: the operator embodies agency so that the field does not collapse.

Conclusion: The Recovery of Human Agency

We are living through a transformation unprecedented in human history: a world in which artificial systems increasingly mediate perception, shape attention, and execute tasks that once required human judgment. The danger is not that machines will become moral agents. It is that human beings, habituated to outsourcing discernment, will forget how to be.

The Grammar of Agency is offered as a counter-movement — a recovery of the interior stance that makes moral action possible. It is not a technique, nor a theory, nor a set of rules. It is a formation architecture: a way of shaping the human person so that when the moment arrives, the act arises from character rather than convenience.

The system is tensegrity. Catholic Social Teaching provides altitude. JPP provides motion. Wu wei provides timing. The gyroscope provides stability. The Agent-Influencer-Witness triad provides relational geometry. The Witness Moment provides ignition.

Artificial intelligence will continue to shape the field. It will process, predict, and propose. But it cannot stand in the Witness Moment. It cannot bear responsibility. It cannot choose the good. Only a human being can do that.

The task ahead is therefore not to resist technology, but to form agents who can remain human within it — agents whose gyroscopes are spinning, whose stabilizers are active, whose timing belts hold, whose dispositions are tuned, and whose presence is real. The future will belong to those who can hold the threshold open long enough for discernment to complete its work.

The person who has been formed will meet the moment.

The person who has not been formed will reach for the taffy.

The Grammar of Agency exists to form the person who places the Kind bar and waits.

Glossary of CST-JPP Terms

This Glossary is the Rosetta Stone for the Grammar of Agency: it defines the core terms phenomenologically, in the moment of the moral act, providing operators with a shared vocabulary for navigating moral moments with clarity and integrity.

Actus. The decisive, embodied action taken by the Agent. The hinge between intention and consequence. The only moment where agency is real.

Agent. The human moral actor who performs actus. Carries the vertical axis (faith, hope, love) and is solely responsible for action unless autonomy is overridden.

Con+Facere. To make with. The moral moment is formed by the Agent, the Influencer(s), and the Witness. Formation is always communal.

CST Fourfold Test. The altitude instrument: Does this restore human dignity? Seed the common good? Strengthen brotherhood and sisterhood? Uplift the little ones?

Four Moves (JPP Kata). Frame — Receive and Sense — Orient and Align — [Wu Wei / Timing Belt] — Act and Integrate. The repeatable kata that forms disposition through praxis.

Horizontal Plane (Virtue Matrix). The stabilizing field of the cardinal virtues: Prudence, Justice, Fortitude, Temperance. LLM-legible but insufficient alone.

Influencer. Any force — person, system, structure, or context — that shapes the field in which the Agent acts. Does not act in the Agent's place.

JPP (Judgment-Premised Processing). The steering mechanism — a kata for navigating chaotic moments with clarity and proportion. A discipline for prudential praxis, not a system for judging people.

Tensegrity. Structural stability through dynamic balance of tension and compression. The architecture holds under load not through rigidity but through balanced forces.

Threshold. the liminal space between Orient & Align and Act & Integrate.

Timing Drift — the failure mode where action precedes discernment, often due to misreading the field rather than failure of character.

Vertical Axis (Transcendent Spine). Faith, Hope, Love — the human-only virtues. Cannot be computed or automated. Orient the Agent toward meaning, purpose, and moral depth.

Witness. The tertiary evaluator who reads the moral vector of the moment. Testifies only when systemic disturbance threatens the Agent's autonomy. If autonomy is intact, the Witness remains silent.

Witness Moment. The instant of actus when the Agent penetrates the horizontal plane and the vertical axis enters the world. Where the wind hits the sail. Where action becomes testimony.

Wu Wei (Timing Belt). From the classical Taoist tradition of ancient China: Lao Tzu, Tao Te Ching (6th c. BCE, Zhou dynasty); Zhuangzi (4th c. BCE). The discipline of active restraint between Orient and Align and Act and Integrate — holding the threshold open while discernment completes its interior work before the exterior act begins. The temporal complement to Aquinas's *recta ratio agibilium*: where Aquinas gives the what of right judgment, wu wei gives the when. Mantra: Let the tea steep. Gather seeds. Scent tea. Palm seeds. Breathe. Ground.

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